

FEDERAL STATE AUTONOMOUS EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTION
FOR HIGHER PROFESSIONAL EDUCATION
NATIONAL RESEARCH UNIVERSITY HIGHER SCHOOL OF
ECONOMICS

Saint-Petersburg School of Social Sciences and Area Studies

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**Migrants' from the Republic of Dagestan perception of their
adaptation in St. Petersburg**

Term paper

Field of study 39.03.01 Sociology

Bachelor Program 'Sociology and Social Informatics'

Supervisor:

PhD

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Saint Petersburg 2026

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1. Introduction

Internal migration is a significant phenomenon which shapes the social and demographic landscape of contemporary Russia. The flow of people from the North Caucasus to large metropolitan areas like Moscow and St. Petersburg is a particularly salient stream. It brings together communities with distinct cultural and religious traditions within the context of a secular, urban environment (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). While academic and public discourse often focuses on the structural integration of these migrants, less attention is paid to the subjective experience of the adaptation process itself.

The Republic of Dagestan is a major donor of internal migrants to Saint-Petersburg. According to the 2020 census, there are 10,9 thousand Dagestanis (Avars, Dargins, Kumyks, Lezgins, Laks, Tabasarans, Aguls, Rutuls, Tsakhurs) in St. Petersburg (Rosstat, 2023). The socioeconomic disparity between Dagestan and St. Petersburg serves as a powerful push-pull factor (Lee, 1966), particularly for the region's youth seeking education, career opportunities, and personal development (Shekera, 2024). However, moving to St. Petersburg exposes Dagestanis to a highly individualistic urban culture, which can lead to acculturative stress and identity negotiation (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023).

While existing research has examined the structural integration and cultural adaptation of North Caucasian migrants in Russian cities (Мукомель, 2016; Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023; Варшавер & Рочева, 2016), and has even begun to explore the specific challenges and potential of Dagestani youth (Shekera, 2024; Shekera, 2025), a significant gap remains. These studies have not specifically focused on the subjective perceptions of the adaptation process from the perspective of a key demographic group, women, whose migration motivations and adaptation challenges differ from those of men due to gendered roles, family responsibilities, and social expectations (Shekera, 2024). The female migrant experience is often rendered invisible in migration scholarship. However, women's motivations, challenges, and coping strategies can differ significantly due to gendered expectations, roles, and experiences both within their communities of origin and in the host society. Furthermore, the specific gender and religious norms within Dagestani society, an Islamic region, shape a unique set of expectations for women that may come into sharper focus or be renegotiated upon migration to a secular metropolis like St. Petersburg (Kostenko, 2017). Understanding female perspective is crucial for a holistic view of the migration process. This study aims to fill this gap by centering the voices and lived experiences of Dagestani women.

Thus, the central research question guiding this study is: How do female migrants from the Republic of Dagestan in St. Petersburg perceive their own adaptation process?

To answer this, the research will explore the female migrants' perceptions of the challenges they face, the coping strategies they employ, the impact of migration on their personal, ethnic, religious, and gender identities, how these women negotiate social categories, manage cultural differences, and make sense of their evolving sense of self within the new environment.

The contribution of this research is twofold. First, it provides empirical depth to theoretical frameworks on ethnicity and integration (Varshaver, 2023; Yinger, 1985) by applying them to the understudied context of internal female migration. Second, it addresses a specific empirical gap by offering insights into the subjective experiences of Dagestani women in St. Petersburg, thereby contributing to the fields of migration studies, gender studies, and urban sociology. Conducted in the contemporary socio-political context of Russia, this research also offers a timely update to previous studies, capturing the experiences of a new generation of migrants.

2. Literature review

2.1. Theoretical perspectives on migration, ethnicity, and integration

Migration has been studied from multiple theoretical perspectives, ranging from classical assimilation frameworks to contemporary transnational and constructivist approaches. Early theories of migration often conceptualized adaptation as a relatively linear process in which migrants gradually become similar to the host society in cultural practices, social participation, and identity (Yinger, 1985). Within this perspective, migration was largely understood as a process of boundary reduction between migrants and the receiving population.

Prior to the detailed analysis of what happens to migrants after their arrival, it is essential to understand the structural forces that set migration in motion. A foundational framework for this is provided by Everett S. Lee (1966). Expanding on Ravenstein's "Laws of Migration" (Ravenstein, 1885), Lee conceptualizes migration as a decision-making process influenced by four primary factors: (1) factors associated with the area of origin, (2) factors associated with the area of destination, (3) intervening obstacles, and (4) personal factors. At

both origin and destination, there exist countless "+" (attracting) and "-" (repelling) factors, the perception of which varies among individuals (Lee, 1966).

Lee hypothesizes that migration increases with the diversity of areas and populations, decreases with the difficulty of surmounting obstacles (such as distance or legal restrictions), and fluctuates with economic cycles. He further theorizes the development of migration streams and counter-streams, noting that for every major flow of people, a compensating flow develops in the opposite direction. The "efficiency" of a stream (its net effect on population redistribution) is higher when migration is driven by negative factors at origin (e.g., famine, persecution) or when intervening obstacles are substantial. Most relevant to the concerns of this review are Lee's propositions on the characteristics of migrants. He posits that migration is inherently selective. Migrants are not a random sample of the population at origin; those responding primarily to "pull" factors (opportunities at destination) tend to be positively selected (e.g., highly educated), while those responding to "push" factors at origin may be negatively selected. Importantly, the difficulty of intervening obstacles heightens positive selection, as only the most capable can overcome them (Lee, 1966).

Lee's model explains the structural determinants of who moves, why, and in what numbers, it does not consider in many details what happens to migrants upon arrival. The "personal factors" he mentions become the central focus of subsequent scholarship, which shifts the analytical lens from the causes of migration to the consequences and processes of adaptation.

Subsequent research has challenged this linear understanding by emphasizing the complexity and multidimensionality of migration experiences. Scholars increasingly highlight the role of cultural exchange, the negotiation of multiple identities, and the maintenance of cross-border social ties in shaping migrants' lives (Schiller et al., 1992). These approaches suggest that migration does not necessarily lead to the erosion of original identities but may instead produce hybrid or multiple forms of belonging.

One of the central themes in migration research concerns migrants' adaptation in receiving societies. Adaptation is commonly analyzed as a multidimensional process encompassing cultural, social, economic, and psychological dimensions (Berry, 1997; Ward, 2001). Scholars examine how migrants interact with the host society, cope with the challenges

associated with cultural change, and maintain connections with their communities of origin while navigating new social environments.

Within this evolving scholarly landscape, J. Milton Yinger (1985) stands as a key author whose work on ethnicity has profoundly influenced subsequent migration research. In his seminal review of the academic study of ethnicity, Yinger provides a foundational framework by introducing the concept of assimilation. He defines it as a process of reducing boundaries between groups, which consists of four distinct aspects: (1) integration (structural) - the distribution of members of an ethnic group across all institutions of society in a pattern similar to that of the general population; (2) acculturation (cultural) - two-way process of acceptance by a group of the values, norms, and customs of society as a whole; (3) identification (psychological) - a shift in an individual's self-identification, where a sense of belonging to a larger society becomes more important than identification with one's ethnic group; and (4) amalgamation (biological) - mixing of the genetic composition of a group with that of society as a whole, primarily through interethnic marriages. Yinger defines ethnicity as “a segment of a larger society whose members are thought, by themselves and/or others, to have a common origin and to share important segments of a common culture and who, in addition, participate in shared activities in which the common origin and culture are significant ingredients.” (Yinger, 1985) According to Yinger the persistence of ethnicity in the modern world is the result of three interconnected forces. First, primordial attachments provide a deep, emotional sense of belonging to "one's own people" based on shared origin and culture. Second, ethnicity serves as a powerful tool for political and economic interests, effectively mobilizing groups to compete for status and resources because it combines rational self-interest with strong affective ties. Third, ethnicity offers a remedy for anomie and alienation, giving individuals a sense of identity, meaning, and social integration. Yinger further emphasizes that ethnicity is not a fixed trait but is situational and flexible, capable of being adapted or even newly constructed to meet contemporary needs (Yinger, 1985).

Later the adaptation of migrants was studied through the perspectives of transnational social fields and acculturation. The transnational perspective, as articulated by Schiller et al. (1992), argues that many contemporary migrants are better understood as "transmigrants" who build social fields that connect their place of origin and settlement. Their adaptation is not a simple one-way process but involves maintaining active, multiple relationships - familial, economic, religious, and political - across geographical boundaries. Schiller et al. discuss

concepts of fluid and multiple identities. Transmigrants navigate their position by reworking different identities - national, ethnic, and racial - simultaneously (Schiller et al., 1992).

According to acculturation theory (Berry, 1997) migration is not merely a geographical shift but a major life event that generates acculturative stress which stems from challenges such as discrimination, language barriers, and intercultural conflicts (Berry et al., 2006; Ward, 2001). Coping - the cognitive and behavioral efforts to manage stress - is an important mediator in the adaptation process (Noh & Kaspar, 2003). Coping patterns are shaped by cultural background. The effectiveness of a coping strategy is also contingent on the migrant's level of acculturation and the host society's context. Berry introduces several acculturation strategies: (1) assimilation - active interaction with the host society's culture rather than the maintenance of the one's cultural identity, (2) separation - avoidance of interaction with host society's culture and focus on the maintenance of the one's cultural identity, (3) integration - equal focus on the interaction with other culture and support to one's cultural values, and (4) marginalization - no interest both in the intercultural interaction and maintenance of one's cultural identity. The preferred strategy influences adaptation outcomes. The integration strategy is associated with better adaptation, while marginalization leads to the worst outcomes. Assimilation and separation typically provide intermediate results (Berry, 1997). The choice of strategy is influenced by the attitudes of the dominant cultural group (Berry, 2001). If the dominant society promotes cultural diversity, an integration strategy emerges. Conversely, demands for assimilation ("melting pot"), forced separation (segregation), or imposed marginalization (exclusion) limit the options for migrants (Berry et al., 2006).

However, today the presumed adaptive superiority of integration appears weaker than Berry assumed. Most existing evidence relies heavily on correlational data, which limits causal interpretations and leaves room for alternative explanations, such as the possibility that better-adapted individuals simply possess greater cognitive resources to maintain bicultural identities (Bierwiazek & Kunst, 2021). Bierwiazek & Kunst reanalysis reveals that acculturation strategies explain very little variance in adaptation (0.8%–1.4%), with longitudinal data showing minimal to no causal effect. This suggests that the role of individual acculturation strategies, including integration, in shaping cross-cultural adaptation may be minimal and the focus should be shifted toward contextual factors like discrimination and social support (Bierwiazek & Kunst, 2021).

Today, while research within other conceptual frameworks, such as acculturation psychology (Berry, 1997) and transnationalism (Schiller et al., 1992), continues to develop, the scholarly discourse on migrant integration has increasingly shifted toward constructivist analyses of ethnic categorization, which have gained particular prominence in contemporary migration studies. This shift builds upon foundational insights into the nature of ethnicity itself. As Rogers Brubaker (2009) argues, a key development in the field has been the move "beyond groupism", that is, beyond treating ethnic groups as substantial, bounded entities. Instead, he advocates studying how ethnicity works in social life: as cognitive schemas, classificatory practices, and ways of seeing the world, not as a "thing" (Brubaker, 2009). Central to this framework is the distinction between ethnic categories (tools for classifying people) and ethnic groups (which imply relational connectedness and collective subjectivity). The analytical task is to investigate the variable degree of "groupness" across contexts, particularly relevant for migration studies, where host society categorizations often diverge from migrants' own self-understandings (Brubaker, 2009, pp. 9–10). Furthermore, Brubaker's cognitive approach clarifies the complex relationship between ethnicity/ethnic identity and culture/cultural identity. In everyday discourse and much scholarly work, ethnicity is often conflated with shared culture. However, Brubaker (2009), drawing on Barth (1969) legacy, emphasizes that ethnicity is fundamentally about boundaries and categorization, not necessarily about shared "cultural stuff." Ethnic boundaries can persist even when cultural content changes significantly, and conversely, substantial cultural similarity does not automatically translate into shared ethnic membership (Brubaker, 2009). This insight helps to disentangle the relationship between cultural identity (which concerns values, norms, language, and everyday practices) and ethnic identity (which concerns perceived common origin, categorical belonging, and we-they distinctions). For migrants, these two dimensions may diverge: one might adopt certain cultural practices of the host society (acculturation) while maintaining a strong ethnic self-identification, or conversely, might retain traditional cultural practices while renegotiating their ethnic category membership in a new context (Brubaker, 2009). Varshaver (2023) follows Brubaker's ideas in his constructivist model of integration as a process of re-categorization within the dichotomous space of "migrant" vs. "local." It also complements Berry's (1997) acculturation strategies by specifying the categorical mechanisms through which migrants navigate between cultural maintenance and intercultural contact.

Just as Brubaker emphasizes the contextual variability of "groupness," Varshaver and Rocheva (2016) highlight that integration is not a one-size-fits-all outcome but a context-dependent process shaped by institutional structures and social interactions. Their multidimensional model offers a way to systematically analyze how migrants' categorical positions shift across different spheres of social life. They conceptualize integration as a multidimensional process which consists of four distinct aspects: (1) cultural (language and norm acquisition), (2) structural (inclusion in labor markets, education, and citizenship systems), (3) social (relationship-building between migrants and non-migrants), and (4) identificational (development of a shared symbolic belonging). This framework echoes and systematizes earlier typologies, such as Yinger's (1985) four aspects of assimilation and Berry's (1997) acculturation strategies. Varshaver and Rocheva (2016) emphasize that integration is not merely a migrant-focused endeavor but a reciprocal process shaped by the institutional and social structures of the receiving society (Варшавер & Рочева, 2016).

The model outlined above identifies what integration looks like across different spheres of social life. Varshaver (2023) extends this line of thinking by asking what categorical mechanisms migrants shift their position in the social structure. His framework posits that ethnicity is organized around categories, membership in which is predominantly inherited, and their associated attributes (stereotypes, indicators, norms, inter-category relations, and discourses). By Varshaver migrant integration is a dynamic process of re-categorization within the dichotomous space of "migrant" vs. "local." Integration can occur through three pathways: (1) reclassifying a "migrant" category as a "local" one, (2) expanding "local" categories by incorporating attributes previously exclusive to "migrant" categories or (3) maintaining the ethnic structure while re-categorizing individuals on a personal level (Varshaver, 2023). This approach resonates with Yinger's view of ethnicity as situational and constructed, and with the transnational perspective of Glick Schiller et al. (1992), which highlights the fluid negotiation of multiple identities.

Varshaver's constructivist framework synthesizes and builds upon the key insights from the other reviewed theories. It is particularly influential in contemporary Russian migration studies, offering a lens that is well-suited to analyzing the complexity and fluidity of migrants' identity, unlike models that posit stable strategies (Varshaver, 2023). Therefore, this study is mostly based on his approach.

This study investigates how social categories like "migrant" and "local" are constructed, negotiated, and subjectively experienced by Dagestani migrants; how they interpret their own position within a social structure; how they perceive the effect of

government policies on their integration; how they perceive and manage their shifting identities in different spheres of life; how they perceive and react to the categories, such as "Caucasian" or "migrant", imposed on them and how they engage with or challenge these labels.

2.2. Contemporary research on Dagestani migration to Saint Petersburg

Internal migration from Dagestan to St. Petersburg, is a significant socio-demographic phenomenon. Migrants from Dagestan are more represented in St. Petersburg than migrants from other republics of the North Caucasus (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). There are 10,9 thousand Dagestanis (Avars, Dargins, Kumyks, Lezgins, Laks, Tabasarans, Aguls, Rutuls, Tsakhurs) in St. Petersburg according to the 2020 census (Rosstat, 2023).

The main reason for migration from Dagestan to Saint-Petersburg is the significant socioeconomic gap. The Republic of Dagestan, ranked 70th in the HDI the Russian Federation in 2019 and St. Petersburg, ranked 2nd (E. Shekera, 2024). In ASI national quality of life rating Saint-Petersburg is the second and Dagestan is not included in the top-20 (Агентство стратегических инициатив). According to the Shekera (2024) survey, for youth (16-24 y.o.), especially for women, the main reason for migration is getting education. For males (25-35 y.o.) opportunities for development, increasing earnings, improving standards of living and finding interesting work are significant. For females (25-35 y.o.) opportunities for development are important but also family circumstances. Key push factors are the lack of quality education, decent work in one's specialty, and infrastructure for self-development. Dagestani migrants are attracted to Saint-Petersburg by opportunities for self-development and good employment prospects. Men value career prospects more, while women value a comfortable environment (infrastructure, living conditions, a calm atmosphere) and family considerations. 30% of Dagestanis plan to stay in Saint-Petersburg permanently. The main problems that contribute to departure from the city are unfavorable climate, family ties (absence of relatives and friends, family circumstances), difficulties in observing religious rites and customs, high stress, high cost of living, information overload, anonymity, high population density, weakening intergenerational ties. For men, climate, religious difficulties, lack of career prospects, and problems with law enforcement are more significant. For women, family reasons, absence of relatives, and stress are more significant (Shekera, 2024).

Research on migrants in the Russian context shows that internal migrants who are part of the “visible minority” as well as external migrants are faced with hostility among the host society (Bessudnov & Shcherbak, 2019; Lepshokova, 2020; Veterinarov & Ivanov, 2018; Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). Caucasians are often perceived as aliens outside their homeland although some of them have Russian citizenship (Стародубровская et al., 2022; Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). In the Levada-Center¹ 2024 survey 21% of respondents answered that residence on the territory of the Russian Federation should be restricted for Caucasians (Левада-Центр¹, 2024). Attitudes towards migrants from the Caucasus vary across Russia’s regions. The level of integration Moscow and the Moscow region residents is lower than in other regions, and in some cases even lower than that of migrants (Мукомель, 2016). This is due to the atomization of the urban environment, low levels of trust, and social disunity. The success of integration is directly linked to the level of integration of the local population: in regions where local residents are more cohesive, migrants integrate more easily (Мукомель, 2016). Besides, the perceived inclusiveness of the social context influences the choice of acculturation strategies aimed at interaction with the host society (integration, assimilation) and reduces the choice of the separation strategy (Lepshokova, 2020). Age, education and financial situation are also important factors affecting integration of internal migrants. Educated people, people with better financial situation and people aged 30-40 are better integrated (Мукомель, 2016).

[Shekera \(2025\)](#) studied the integration potential of Dagestani youth in Saint-Petersburg in three spheres - political, socio-economic and cultural. In the political sphere the survey revealed that formal equality of rights does not ensure real equality of opportunity because administrative barriers (city registration) and ethnic discrimination by government agencies significantly reduce integration potential in the political and legal spheres. For example, migrants experience difficulties with enrolling their children in school, because local children with city registration have higher priority. It is harder for migrants to get social guarantees which require registration. Integration potential in the socioeconomic sphere is polarized. On the one hand, the vast majority of young people are actively involved in socio-economic life. On the other, there are severe barriers in the labor market and, especially, in the housing market, where ethnic discrimination is most acute and directly hinders migrants' opportunities. As for the cultural sphere Dagestanis get a very high level of everyday ethnic discrimination from the host society. At the same time, migrants demonstrate

¹ The Levada Center has been included in the register of non-commercial organizations acting as foreign agents by the Ministry of Justice of the Russian Federation.

high adaptability, successfully manage their daily lives, and their group remains open to interaction, however cohesive. Religion serves as a key marker of identity and social boundaries. To sum up, integration is most successful where there are clear institutional rules and opportunities and least successful where subjective decisions and stereotypes play a significant role ([E. A. Shekera, 2025](#)).

Dagestani migrants, being fluent in Russian, do not face a serious language barrier. However, their adaptation is primarily associated with navigating intercultural conflicts arising from differing norms and values (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). Starodubrovskaja Sitkevich in their study of North Caucasian migrants in St. Petersburg discuss cultural differences which concern their informants. Differences include: the attitudes toward elders and women (in the Caucasus elders are treated with more respect and reverence and women are protected, looked after and more dependent on men); modesty (in the Caucasus women dress more modestly); attitudes towards guests and neighbours (Caucasians have closer contact with neighbours and tend to help strangers, which is not common in Saint-Petersburg); approach to raising children (Caucasians strive to instill traditions, respect for elders, and the unacceptability of bad habits, while in Saint-Petersburg children are more free in these aspects); spending free time (smoking, getting drunk, staying late, socializing with the opposite sex, which are common ways to spend time in Saint-Petersburg, are unacceptable for Caucasians). Starodubrovskaja & Sitkevich study revealed that cultural distance and the specific individualistic, heterogeneous culture of the metropolis significantly shape the adaptation process. First-generation migrants often experience migration shock and tend to adopt a strategy of separation, seeking refuge within their familiar ethnic and cultural circles. Although, integration was more common among students. Acculturation through subcultures like the Islamic community was also observed. In contrast, second-generation migrants, growing up in Saint-Petersburg, organically adopted urban cultural patterns, which led to strategies of integration or assimilation and created a significant intergenerational gap. Maintaining strong ties with their home regions remained important for all migrants. Over time, some began to perceive the norms and routines of their communities of origin as alien, while their life strategies often kept future options open between St. Petersburg and the North Caucasus (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023).

The specific experiences of female migrants are shaped not only by their ethnic and cultural background but also by gender. For migrants from regions with strong Islamic

traditions, such as Dagestan, gender attitudes and roles can be a central axis of both internal identity and external interaction with the host society. Kostenko's (2017) multi-level analysis of Muslim migrants in Western Europe demonstrates that gender attitudes are not solely determined by religion but are influenced by a complex interplay of individual characteristics and the institutional context of both the sending and receiving societies. This highlights the need to examine how Dagestani women navigate the potential dissonance between the gender norms of their communities of origin and the more liberal, secular expectations prevalent in a metropolis like St. Petersburg. Their adaptation process may involve specific negotiations around dress, public behavior, education, and career, which differ from the experiences of their male counterparts. This study directly addresses this gap by focusing on the subjective perceptions of these women (Kostenko, 2017).

While prior studies, such as those by Starodubrovskaja and Sitkevich (2023) and Shekera (2024, 2025), have examined the integration of North Caucasian and Dagestani migrants, they have not specifically focused on the subjective perceptions of adaptation among women. Their work provides crucial context on structural barriers and cultural differences, but a deep exploration of how women themselves perceive and interpret their identity negotiation, coping strategies, and overall adaptation journey remains an underdeveloped area. This study contributes to the previous literature by applying a constructivist lens specifically to the experiences of female internal migrants. It offers empirical depth on how Dagestani women in St. Petersburg negotiate social categories, manage cultural and gendered expectations, and interpret their own adaptation strategies, thereby providing a necessary complement to existing structural and group-level analyses.

3. Methodology

This research aims to explore the perceived impact of migration to Saint Petersburg on the personal identity and social integration of women from Dagestan, their perceived challenges and strategies related to adaptation in a new cultural environment, and how migration influences their perception of their own ethnic, religious, and gender identities. A phenomenological design was chosen as the most appropriate approach, as it focuses on capturing the essence of the lived experience of adaptation from the participants' own perspectives.

Data were collected through semi-structured, in-depth interviews, which allowed for depth, flexibility, and the exploration of unanticipated themes. A pilot interview was

conducted to test the interview guide and assess the relevance of the proposed themes. Following the pilot interview, several questions were reformulated and minor adjustments were made to the structure of the guide. However, the core thematic domains remained unchanged. Since the pilot interview addressed the same substantive topics as the subsequent interviews, it was included in the final dataset and analyzed alongside the other interviews.

The final interview guide included six thematic sections. The first section focused on demographic background and migration history, including motivations for migration, expectations associated with moving to Saint Petersburg, and future migration plans. The second section explored structural and economic adaptation through questions about education, employment, housing, access to opportunities, and experiences of discrimination in the labour and housing markets. The third section examined social adaptation, including relationships with local residents and co-ethnics, feelings of belonging and exclusion, experiences of loneliness, social participation, and leisure activities. The fourth section focused on cultural adaptation and identity, exploring perceived cultural differences between Dagestan and Saint Petersburg, changes in everyday practices, identity transformation, and translocal ties with relatives and communities in Dagestan. The fifth section addressed coping strategies and adaptation challenges, including sources of support, stress management, and thoughts about return migration. Finally, the sixth section examined gender and family-related aspects of migration, including perceptions of gender roles, women's freedom and social position, family dynamics, childrearing practices, language use, and the transmission of Dagestani culture to the next generation.

A total of 10 interviews were conducted. Three interviews were conducted face-to-face. Five interviews were conducted as audio calls via VKontakte. One participant agreed to a video call. Each interview was recorded using a voice recorder except one, which was conducted through real-time text correspondence on VKontakte. During this interview, questions were asked interactively throughout the conversation following the logic of a semi-structured interview. The use of different interview formats reflected participants' preferences and comfort levels. Many respondents were reluctant to participate in video communication and preferred audio-only or text-based interaction, possibly because they felt uncomfortable discussing personal experiences, cultural norms, or gender-related issues on camera.

All data were anonymized; names and identifying details were removed and replaced with pseudonyms. The sample consisted of women who were born in Dagestan, had migrated to Saint Petersburg, and were residing there at the time of the study.

The final sample consisted of 10 participants aged between 20 and 54 years. Participants migrated to Saint Petersburg for various reasons, including higher education, employment, marriage, and family-related circumstances. The sample included both married and unmarried women with diverse educational and occupational backgrounds. Detailed demographic information about participants is presented in Appendix 1.

I am an external researcher and not a member of the Dagestani community. My position as a woman researching female migrants may have facilitated rapport-building while simultaneously shaping the interaction and the data collected. I acknowledge that my outsider status may initially have hindered trust but may also have encouraged participants to explain cultural nuances more explicitly.

A purposive sampling strategy was used to select information-rich cases. The final sample consisted of 10 participants. I was personally acquainted with two respondents prior to the study. Two additional participants were recruited through referrals from these initial contacts. The remaining participants were recruited through thematic VKontakte communities related to Dagestani migrants and professionals in Saint Petersburg, including groups such as “Association of Doctors from Dagestan in Saint Petersburg” and “Commonwealth of Dagestani Youth”. Snowball sampling was therefore combined with targeted online recruitment.

Recruiting participants proved challenging due to the relatively closed nature of the community and concerns regarding privacy. Many respondents were unwilling to share the contact information of acquaintances who might have been eligible for participation. In addition, approximately one hundred women were contacted through VKontakte messages and thematic communities, yet only six agreed to participate. One of these respondents declined any form of voice or video communication and agreed to participate only through text correspondence. This low response rate reflects the difficulties of gaining access to participants within a community where trust and personal networks play an important role (Стародубовская & Ситкевич, 2023).

Due to the closed nature of the community and the importance of trust, snowball sampling was employed alongside online recruitment. On the one hand, acquaintances and referrals helped build trust. On the other hand, they may have contributed to caution and socially desirable responses given the sensitivity of some topics discussed.

All interviews were transcribed using the AI-based transcription platform Riverside.fm. Speaker attribution and transcript formatting were subsequently refined using DeepSeek. The researcher manually reviewed all transcripts while listening to the original

recordings, corrected transcription errors, verified speaker attribution, and edited inaccuracies where necessary. During transcript preparation, segments unrelated to the research questions were removed from the analytical corpus. These included extended discussions not directly connected to migration and adaptation as well as personal conversations between the researcher and participants that were unrelated to the study. This procedure was undertaken to improve analytical focus and reduce the inclusion of irrelevant codes during subsequent analysis.

Data were analyzed using thematic analysis. The analytical process combined researcher-led interpretation with AI-assisted coding tools. During transcript review, preliminary codes were noted manually by the researcher. The interview transcripts were subsequently imported into QualCoder for qualitative data management. AI-assisted coding within QualCoder was initially explored but was found to produce inconsistent results. Therefore, each interview was analyzed individually using DeepSeek, which was used to identify potential codes and supporting quotations from the transcripts. All suggested codes were critically reviewed by the researcher, who removed irrelevant codes, modified code labels where necessary, and added codes that had not been identified automatically but were considered analytically important.

The coding process followed an inductive approach, meaning that codes and themes emerged from the data rather than being derived from a predetermined theoretical framework. The final codebook consisted of 616 codes. A complete list of codes is provided in Appendix 2.

Following coding, the complete codebook was imported into DeepSeek and ChatGPT to explore possible thematic structures. Several alternative groupings of codes were compared and evaluated. The final thematic framework was selected and refined by the researcher based on its coherence, analytical usefulness, and ability to represent participants' experiences accurately. The analysis resulted in nine overarching themes describing adaptation. A summary of themes is presented in Appendix 3.

4. Limitations

This study, being exploratory and qualitative in nature, has several limitations. First, the findings are based on a small, non-representative sample and therefore cannot be generalized to all female Dagestani migrants in Saint Petersburg or elsewhere. The goal is not statistical generalization but an in-depth understanding of subjective experiences.

Second, the use of snowball sampling, while necessary for accessing a relatively closed community, may introduce bias, as participants are likely to share certain network-related characteristics, experiences, or viewpoints.

Third, as mentioned above, my position as an outsider and the use of initial contacts could have contributed to socially desirable responses, where participants tailored their answers to what they perceived as acceptable or expected. The fact that some participants were personally acquainted with the researcher may also have influenced the depth and openness of particular discussions.

Fourth, the recruitment process itself may have introduced selection bias. Although approximately one hundred women were contacted through VKontakte, only six agreed to participate. Individuals who chose to participate may differ systematically from those who declined, potentially limiting the diversity of perspectives represented in the study.

Fifth, the use of multiple interview formats (face-to-face interviews, audio calls, a video call, and one text-based interview) may have influenced the depth and nature of the data collected. Different communication formats provide different opportunities for rapport-building and self-disclosure, which may affect participants' responses.

Finally, the study relied on automated transcription and AI-assisted thematic analysis. Although all transcripts were manually reviewed and corrected where necessary, some transcription inaccuracies may have remained unnoticed. Likewise, while AI-generated themes and codes were carefully verified and refined manually, certain nuances, themes, or codes may have been overlooked during the analytical process. Therefore, the findings should be interpreted with an awareness of the limitations associated with AI-assisted qualitative data analysis.

As the sole researcher, my own interpretations and assumptions may also have influenced the data collection and analysis process despite continuous efforts to remain reflexive throughout the study.

5. Assumptions

This study follows constructivist and phenomenological approaches discussed earlier (Brubaker, 2009; Varshaver, 2023). It assumes that adaptation is a subjective and socially constructed experience shaped by personal background, social interaction, and the broader context of life in Saint-Petersburg. Therefore, participants may experience and interpret

adaptation differently. The research also assumes that identity is dynamic and context-dependent. Ethnic, religious, gender, and migrant identities are understood as flexible and shaped through social interaction (Brubaker, 2009; Varshaver, 2023).

Consistent with the phenomenological orientation of the study, participants are viewed as capable of reflecting on and describing their lived experiences. Semi-structured interviews are therefore considered appropriate for exploring these meanings, while acknowledging that responses are influenced by memory, context, and interaction with the researcher. The study further assumes that knowledge is co-constructed between researcher and participants. My positionality as a woman and outsider to the Dagestani community may influence trust, communication, and interpretation, making reflexivity important throughout the research process. Finally, the research assumes that migrant adaptation is shaped not only by individual efforts but also by social context, including discrimination, institutional barriers, and public attitudes toward migrants from the North Caucasus (Мукомель, 2016; Lepshokova, 2020; Shekera, 2025).

6. Results

The thematic analysis identified nine major themes related to the adaptation experiences of Dagestani women in Saint Petersburg. These themes concern migration motivations, emotional adaptation, everyday integration, experiences of discrimination, social support networks, cultural differences, gender role negotiation, identity maintenance, and structural barriers and opportunities.

6.1. Migration as a family-embedded life transition

Participants described migration as a decision embedded within family relationships, parental influence, educational aspirations, and gender norms. Several respondents moved to Saint Petersburg to pursue higher education. Others were following their husbands who wanted economic opportunities and career development unavailable in Dagestan.

Family members often played a decisive role in migration decisions. In some cases, parents actively encouraged migration, particularly for educational purposes. One participant explained that her father presented studying in Saint Petersburg as an alternative to early marriage. Another respondent noted that her father's positive memories and emotional attachment to the city influenced her own perception of Saint Petersburg before migration. Migration was also connected to broader aspirations for independence. Several women

associated Saint Petersburg with greater educational and professional opportunities, higher salaries, and the possibility of achieving economic self-sufficiency. Future migration plans were often characterized by uncertainty. Most of the respondents intended to remain in Saint Petersburg in the near future, but imagined returning to Dagestan later in life, particularly after retirement. This suggests that migration was often perceived not as a permanent rupture with the place of origin but as one stage in a longer life trajectory.

6.2. Emotional costs of migration and the experience of separation

Despite the opportunities associated with migration, participants frequently described the adaptation process as emotionally difficult. Homesickness, loneliness, and separation from family emerged as common experiences, particularly during the initial period after arrival. Several respondents recalled periods of intense emotional distress. Some described crying frequently, wanting to return home, or feeling unable to adjust to life in the city. Feelings of isolation were especially common among participants who migrated alone and initially lacked close social connections in Saint Petersburg. Parents, and mothers in particular, occupied an important place in participants' narratives. Emotional attachment to family members often remained strong despite physical distance. Daily communication through phone calls and messaging applications served as a key mechanism for maintaining emotional wellbeing. Participants also described missing specific aspects of life in Dagestan, including family gatherings, religious holidays, local nature, and a sense of familiarity. Missing celebrations such as Uraza-Bairam were particularly emotionally significant for some respondents because these events traditionally involve extensive family interaction. Although homesickness generally decreased over time, emotional ties to Dagestan remained important throughout the adaptation process. Regular communication with relatives functioned as an emotional bridge connecting participants to their place of origin.

6.3. Adaptation through competence, time, and everyday practice

Participants generally described adaptation as a gradual process rather than a single event. Time emerged as one of the most frequently mentioned factors facilitating successful adaptation. Many respondents reported that their first months in Saint Petersburg were difficult but that everyday experience gradually increased their confidence and sense of belonging. Adaptation was often described in practical terms, including learning how the city functions, developing social networks, and becoming familiar with local norms and routines.

Employment played an important role in this process. Work provided opportunities to interact with local residents, develop professional skills, and establish daily routines. Several participants emphasized that beginning work helped them feel integrated into the city and reduced feelings of isolation. Some respondents reported that after several years they no longer perceived themselves as outsiders. Instead, they described feeling comfortable navigating urban life and identified Saint Petersburg as a place where they could successfully build their future. Adaptation was therefore experienced as the gradual acquisition of social and practical competence rather than the abandonment of previous identities.

6.4. Negotiating boundaries, discrimination, and migrant status

Participants' experiences of discrimination varied considerably. Some respondents reported frequent encounters with prejudice and others stated that they had rarely experienced discrimination or had not perceived themselves as targets of negative treatment. The most common forms of discrimination were connected to ethnic stereotypes. Participants reported instances of verbal hostility, negative assumptions based on appearance, and situations in which they felt categorized as outsiders despite being Russian citizens. Housing discrimination also emerged as a recurring issue, with several respondents describing difficulties finding accommodation after revealing their place of origin. Experiences of discrimination highlighted the ambiguity of participants' social position. Although they were internal migrants and citizens of the Russian Federation, they were sometimes categorized as "Caucasian" or "non-Russian" by others. In response, some participants actively asserted their citizenship and challenged discriminatory assumptions. Participants adopted different coping strategies. They confronted discriminatory behaviour directly or preferred to ignore incidents, use humour, or frame discrimination as a temporary inconvenience. The diversity of responses suggests that participants actively interpreted and negotiated imposed social categories rather than passively accepting them.

6.5. Social networks, community, and sources of support

Social relationships played a central role in adaptation. Family members, relatives, friends, and co-ethnic networks provided emotional support, practical assistance, and a sense of continuity during periods of transition. Many participants relied heavily on other Dagestanis living in Saint Petersburg. Shared language, customs, values, and experiences facilitated trust and mutual understanding. Organizations such as Dagestani youth associations

also provided opportunities to maintain social connections and participate in community life. Most of the participants reported having close Russian friends, but some of them described their social circles as consisting almost exclusively of co-ethnics. Limited opportunities for interaction, rather than active avoidance, were often cited as the reason for the absence of local friendships. These findings suggest that adaptation occurs not only through individual efforts but also through participation in social networks that provide resources, support, and a sense of belonging.

6.6. Cultural difference, everyday norms, and urban-rural contrast

Participants frequently interpreted their experiences through comparisons between Dagestan and Saint Petersburg. Cultural differences were discussed in relation to social interaction, neighbour relations, hospitality, communication styles, and everyday behaviour. One of the most commonly mentioned differences concerned relationships between neighbours. Respondents contrasted the close-knit and supportive communities they associated with Dagestan with the more distant and individualistic social environment of Saint Petersburg. Several participants expressed surprise at the limited interaction between neighbours in the city. Hospitality and mutual assistance also emerged as important points of comparison. Participants often described Dagestani culture as more collective and socially involved, whereas Saint Petersburg was associated with greater privacy and individual autonomy. Other differences included climate, housing conditions, and public behaviour. Some respondents mentioned that the colder climate and different communication styles initially required adjustment. Such comparisons suggest that adaptation involves not only practical adjustment but also ongoing interpretation of cultural differences and similarities.

6.7. Gender, family roles, and women's autonomy

Migration influenced participants' perceptions of gender roles, family expectations, and personal autonomy. Many respondents compared gender norms in Dagestan and Saint Petersburg and reflected on how these differences affected their own lives. Participants often described Saint Petersburg as providing greater freedom for women. Several reported feeling less constrained by social surveillance and community expectations after migration. The perceived importance of public opinion and concerns about "what people will say" appeared weaker in the urban environment. At the same time, participants did not necessarily reject Dagestani gender norms. Instead, many selectively adopted aspects of both contexts. Some

appreciated greater opportunities for education and employment while continuing to value family-oriented gender roles. Changes in household labour division were also reported. Employment outside the home sometimes contributed to more egalitarian domestic arrangements, although traditional expectations remained important in many families. Overall, migration encouraged reflection on gender roles and provided opportunities for participants to negotiate their own positions between different normative frameworks.

6.8. Maintaining ethnic, religious, and linguistic identity across migration

Participants consistently emphasized the importance of maintaining connections to Dagestani culture despite living outside the republic. Cultural continuity was expressed through traditions, language use, religious practices, and childrearing strategies. Most respondents reported actively preserving cultural practices and transmitting them to their children. Respect for elders, family values, and knowledge of cultural traditions were frequently described as important aspects of upbringing. Language occupied a particularly important place in participants' narratives. While Russian was often the dominant language of everyday life, many respondents expressed a strong desire to preserve Dagestani languages within the family. However, some acknowledged language shift and difficulties transmitting native languages to younger generations. Religion also remained an important source of identity. Several participants reported becoming more religiously observant after migration, while others emphasized continuity in their religious practices. Religious holidays and rituals often served as important links connecting participants to Dagestan. These findings suggest that participants actively negotiated how these identities would be maintained, adapted, and transmitted in a new social environment.

6.9. Structural opportunities and constraints in adaptation

Participants' adaptation experiences were shaped not only by interpersonal interactions but also by structural conditions. Access to employment, housing, childcare, and educational opportunities influenced how easily respondents were able to establish themselves in Saint Petersburg. Employment opportunities were generally perceived positively. Several participants reported finding work relatively quickly and viewed the city as offering greater professional possibilities than Dagestan. At the same time, some respondents encountered barriers related to lack of experience, maternity leave, or employer prejudice. Housing

emerged as a more problematic area. Participants described difficulties securing accommodation, particularly when landlords held negative stereotypes about migrants from the North Caucasus. Some respondents also mentioned administrative barriers related to registration and access to services. Nevertheless, participants often emphasized their ability to overcome these obstacles through persistence, social support, and accumulated experience. Adaptation was therefore understood not only as an individual process but also as one shaped by broader institutional and structural conditions.

7. Discussion

This study explored how female migrants from the Republic of Dagestan perceive their adaptation in Saint Petersburg. The findings demonstrate that adaptation is a multidimensional and dynamic process shaped by structural opportunities, social relationships, cultural differences, gender norms, and ongoing negotiations of identity. Adaptation was experienced by respondents as a continuous process of balancing participation in urban life with the maintenance of ethnic, religious, and family ties. One of the central findings concerns the gradual nature of adaptation. Participants frequently described adaptation as something that developed through time, everyday experience, employment, and increasing familiarity with the city. This finding supports previous research on North Caucasian migrants, which emphasizes the importance of practical participation in urban life and everyday interaction for successful adaptation (Стародубровская & Ситкевич, 2023). The findings also correspond with Varshaver and Rocheva's (2016) multidimensional understanding of integration, according to which integration develops across social, cultural, structural, and identificational domains rather than occurring simultaneously in all areas of life.

The study also demonstrates the importance of social networks and community support. Family members, relatives, friends, and co-ethnic organizations played a significant role in helping participants navigate migration-related challenges. These networks provided emotional support, practical assistance, and a sense of continuity. At the same time, reliance on co-ethnic networks did not necessarily prevent interaction with local residents. Many participants maintained both Dagestani and Russian social ties. This finding is consistent with transnational perspectives on migration, which argue that migrants often maintain multiple social connections simultaneously rather than replacing one social world with another (Schiller et al., 1992).

A particularly important finding concerns the persistence of ethnic and religious identities. Most participants actively maintained cultural traditions, religious practices, and family values while adapting to life in Saint Petersburg. This finding aligns with contemporary constructivist approaches. As Brubaker (2009) argues, ethnicity should not be understood as a fixed set of cultural traits but as a flexible process of categorization and identification. Participants adapted to new social environments while continuing to identify strongly with Dagestani culture. This finding illustrates that adaptation and ethnic identification can coexist.

The findings further support Varshaver's (2023) argument that integration involves processes of re-categorization rather than the disappearance of ethnic distinctions. Participants frequently described situations in which they were categorized by others as "Caucasians" or "external migrants" despite being citizens of the Russian Federation. Their responses suggest that adaptation involved negotiating these imposed categories. Some challenged stereotypes directly, while others ignored discriminatory incidents or interpreted them as isolated experiences. These findings indicate that migrants are not passive recipients of social labels but active participants in defining their own social position.

Experiences of discrimination emerged as an important aspect of adaptation. Consistent with previous studies (Bessudnov & Shcherbak, 2019; Shekera, 2025), respondents reported ethnic stereotyping and difficulties in the housing market. However, experiences varied between participants. Some encountered discrimination regularly, whereas others reported few negative experiences. This variation supports recent critiques of acculturation theory which emphasize the importance of contextual factors, such as social support and inclusiveness, over individual adaptation strategies alone (Bierwiazzonek & Kunst, 2021).

The findings also highlight the gendered nature of migration and adaptation. Participants often described Saint Petersburg as providing greater freedom and broader educational and professional opportunities for women. At the same time, they rarely rejected traditional family values entirely. Instead, most respondents selectively combined elements of both social contexts. Migration did not produce a complete transformation of gender norms. Rather, participants actively negotiated their positions between different cultural expectations.

Finally, the findings demonstrate that adaptation is shaped by both individual agency and structural conditions. Employment opportunities, educational institutions, housing markets, and administrative procedures influenced participants' experiences alongside personal characteristics and social relationships. Respondents generally viewed Saint

Petersburg as offering greater opportunities than Dagestan, but structural barriers such as housing discrimination affected their adaptation. This supports previous research showing that integration depends not only on migrants' efforts but also on the openness and accessibility of receiving institutions (Баршавер & Рочева, 2016; Shekera, 2025).

Overall, the findings suggest that adaptation among female migrants from Dagestan is best understood as a process of negotiation rather than assimilation. Participants developed the skills necessary to participate successfully in urban life and simultaneously preserved important aspects of their ethnic, religious, and family identities.

8. Conclusion

This study examined how female migrants from the Republic of Dagestan perceive their adaptation in Saint Petersburg. Drawing on 10 semi-structured interviews, it explored participants' experiences of migration, adaptation challenges, identity negotiations, and sources of support. The findings indicate that adaptation is a gradual process influenced by social relationships, cultural differences, structural opportunities, and personal experiences. Participants generally viewed Saint Petersburg as a place offering educational, professional, and personal opportunities, but also presenting challenges related to discrimination, housing, and cultural adjustment. Social networks, particularly family and co-ethnic communities, played an important role in facilitating adaptation and providing emotional support. The study demonstrates that adaptation does not necessarily involve abandoning ethnic, religious, or cultural identities. Instead, participants combined elements of Dagestani and Saint Petersburg life, creating flexible forms of belonging that incorporated both continuity and change. Migration also encouraged reflection on gender roles and personal autonomy, with many respondents describing increased opportunities for self-development, at the same time, continuing to value family-oriented traditions. The research contributes to the literature on internal migration in Russia by focusing on the subjective experiences of Dagestani women, a group that has received limited scholarly attention. By applying a constructivist perspective on ethnicity and integration, the study highlights how migrants negotiate social categories, identities, and boundaries in everyday life. Several limitations should be acknowledged. The study is based on a relatively small sample of 10 participants and therefore cannot be considered representative of all Dagestani women living in Saint Petersburg. In addition, participants were recruited primarily through personal networks and community organizations, which may have influenced the perspectives represented in the data. Future

research could include larger and more diverse samples, compare female and male migrants, or examine generational differences among Dagestani migrants in Russian metropolitan areas. Despite these limitations, the findings provide valuable insight into the lived experiences of female internal migrants and demonstrate the complexity of adaptation as a process involving both continuity and transformation. Understanding these experiences contributes to broader discussions of migration, gender, identity, and integration in contemporary Russian society.

Description of the application of AI

1. Entire text of the term paper (structure, drafting, editing, translation)

<i>Purpose</i>	To generate an initial structure, improve academic style, correct grammar and lexis, translate selected passages into English.
<i>Method of use</i>	The author wrote all the content independently. Generative models were used to produce draft variants of certain paragraphs, which were then substantially revised, edited, and verified by the author. The models also helped rephrase sentences for clarity and academic tone, correct punctuation and spelling, and suggest synonym replacements. No section was used in a purely generated form without authorial revision.
<i>Models used</i>	ChatGPT (https://chatgpt.com/); DeepSeek (https://www.deepseek.com/)
<i>Effectiveness</i>	Models reduced time spent on routine editing, grammar checks, and stylistic

	polishing. All outputs were critically reviewed and corrected by the author.
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2. Transcription of interviews

<i>Purpose</i>	To convert audio recordings of interviews into written text for qualitative analysis.
<i>Method of use</i>	Automated transcription was performed using Riverside.fm's transcription tool. Speaker diarization was additionally performed using DeepSeek. Each transcript was manually verified and corrected by the author while listening to the original audio recordings, as automated transcription contained inaccuracies in both wording and speaker attribution.
<i>Models used</i>	Riverside.fm transcription tool (https://riverside.com/transcription); DeepSeek (https://www.deepseek.com/)
<i>Effectiveness</i>	Automated transcription saved time but required substantial manual correction. DeepSeek's speaker separation was helpful but also required manual verification. The final transcripts were author-verified and accurate.

3. Coding of interview data

<i>Purpose</i>	To perform initial thematic coding of interview transcripts.
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<i>Method of use</i>	AI-assisted coding was applied. First, transcripts were processed in Qualcoder using its integrated Blablador model. Due to slow performance and imprecise code generation, the author switched to DeepSeek. Each interview transcript was uploaded to DeepSeek, which generated a table of codes and corresponding quotations. The author then manually reviewed every code, removed codes related to quotations taken out of context, added missing codes, and refined the coding scheme.
<i>Models used</i>	Qualcoder Software (https://qualcoder.org/doc/en/) with Blablador (https://blablador.fz-juelich.de/login); DeepSeek (https://www.deepseek.com/)
<i>Effectiveness</i>	Qualcoder/Blablador was inefficient. DeepSeek was significantly more effective in generating an initial list of codes. However, full manual verification and correction were essential. The final coding reflects authorial judgment.

4. Thematic structuring of results

<i>Purpose</i>	To identify possible ways of grouping codes into higher-level themes.
<i>Method of use</i>	The author uploaded the final code table to DeepSeek and ChatGPT separately. Each model proposed several alternative thematic structures. The author compared these

	proposals, selected the most appropriate one, and then reworked, renamed, and reorganized themes based on her own understanding of the data. The final nine themes reflect authorial interpretation.
<i>Models used</i>	ChatGPT (https://chatgpt.com/); DeepSeek (https://www.deepseek.com/)
<i>Effectiveness</i>	Models provided useful brainstorming and different organizational logics. The final thematic structure was determined by the author.

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Appendices

- Appendix 1. Demographic characteristics of participants
Available by the link: [📄 summary table](#)
- Appendix 2. Codebook
Available by the link: [📄 codebook](#)
- Appendix 3. Themes
Available by the link: [📄 themes](#)
- Appendix 4. Interview recordings and transcripts
Available by the link: [🎧 Interviews](#)
- Appendix 5. Interview guide
Available by the link: [📄 Interview Guide](#)